

FIRST EDITION



# ***NEWSLETTER***

## **2025**

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# INTRODUCTION

Debating to a competitive debater is like a bass drum to circadian rhythm. Like a heartbeat, it beats as naturally as the flowers that bloom in the spring. Every individual, every team, every institution has a unique tale to tell of their ebbs and flows. The dusk of a great era breathes the prologue of a new book, one patiently waiting to be written in.

What makes the debating community so beautiful is not the focused rivalries forged in the depths of the nether, but rather the camaraderie that breathes through this intense competition of ideas. The friendships and fellowship forged through the fierce showdown amongst unseemly permutations of individuals are ones that seem to last a few lifetimes. It's paradoxical, but somehow, it works.

Twelve months. Fourteen tournaments. Seventy-one prelims. Fifty-four knockouts. You might think this represents Mike Tyson's career record, but you would be sorely mistaken. These statistics represent so much more than that — not just of one amazing individual, but of the blood, sweat, and tears of the entire Sri Lankan debate circuit over the past year.

The DC Newsletter is a celebration — a celebration of progression and of the bard. Inside these pages you will find lucid accounts, reflections, and insights by a multitude of accomplished individuals precious to Sri Lankan debating, where each word tells a unique story: of victory, of defeat, of jubilation, and of melancholy. Think of it like a vivid snapshot of a moment in our little universe, and the final note before the embrace of a new melody.

As the seeds of the past become the fruit of the future, we celebrate our present successes and await what the future holds for the tiny (but mighty!) world of Sri Lankan debating.

# NATIONAL TEAM Q&A

[www.thedebaterscouncil.lk](http://www.thedebaterscouncil.lk)

**WE ASKED THE MEMBERS OF THE 2025  
NATIONAL TEAM SOME BURNING QUESTIONS  
AND THEY ANSWERED!**



# NATIONAL TEAM Q&A

## What was your experience like at WSDC?

"It was fun. As much as I am upset about things not going the way we wished they would, that's obviously something we can never control, I think we realized, after break night, that as corny as it sounds, the bond we had between everyone as a consequence of being in team was the most important thing (at least I) experienced during, and after wsdc. Additionally, I got to meet so many people that shared the common interest of debating and being able to meet everyone and getting to have fun with them was in itself a great experience :)"

- Rudesh Ram -

"It was surreal. To see what actually happens at a WSDC round in person, as opposed to through a screen, and it's an experience I value."

- Dihen Udumalagala -

"Stressful, but fun. I made a lot of friends."

- Savith Wijesundara -

"Fun, enlightening but also a bit bittersweet."

- Akein Bandara -

"It was fun we got to meet a lot of new people and watch really good debates."

- Nimansa Jayasundera -

## What was the most memorable off-stage moment with your teammates?

"Personally, in retrospect, it would have to be Akein's (**unfunny**) jokes as much as I'd hate to admit it, but also the puppies we met in Panama were a close second."

- Rudesh Ram -

"Probably exploring Panama, or going through the pain of having to transfer hotels after a gruelling day of debate."

- Dihen Udumalagala -

"Playing a lot of pool at Dihen's house."

- Savith Wijesundara -

"It's between clocking my head three times in a row in a bus and all the fun meals."

- Akein Bandara -

"Exploring Panama and getting into fake fights with Rudesh."

- Nimansa Jayasundera -

## What is one important thing you learned from WSDC 2025 that you will carry forward in your debating career?

"I think it's to handle losses, because for as disappointed as we were, only after our losses did I realize that there's so much more to wsdc than the conclusion you reach in rounds, that the people you meet in team and the time we got to spend together was also as important, I'll forever keep in mind that wins on paper isn't the make it or break it."

- Rudesh Ram -

"That no one is untouchable. Even the best at the worlds stage are fallible, and beatable, it's just about doing the right things at the right time, and putting in your absolute best."

- Dihen Udumalagala -

"I probably somewhat knew this before, but saw it much more clearly at Worlds. Debating isn't about knowing the most spec, but being the most convincing, regardless of the truth. It is sometimes easier to succeed if you view debating more as a game than a rigorous exercise."

- Savith Wijesundara -

"Simplicity, being straightforward, clarity and trying to be more confident instead of being stuck in my own head."

- Akein Bandara -

"Success is non linear and that one bad speech is not the end of the world."

- Nimansa Jayasundera -



## NATIONAL TEAM Q&A

### What advice would you give to someone dreaming of making it to the national team?

"The philosophy I've always lived by, is to always try your best. There are always going to be so many variables that may lead to an undesirable outcome, but you also have to keep in mind that not getting in is a very real possibility, as much as getting in is also one, if you keep that in mind and you're still willing to try your hardest to get into team, you're already halfway there :)"

- **Rudesh Ram** -

"Don't be consumed by your desire to get on a team, win a tournament, receive an award, etc. You will burn out, and there is no worse feeling. So just, have fun with it, I guess."

- **Dihein Udumalagala** -

"Watch a lot of WSDC debates, make use of the debrief videos from the DC, redeliver your speeches."

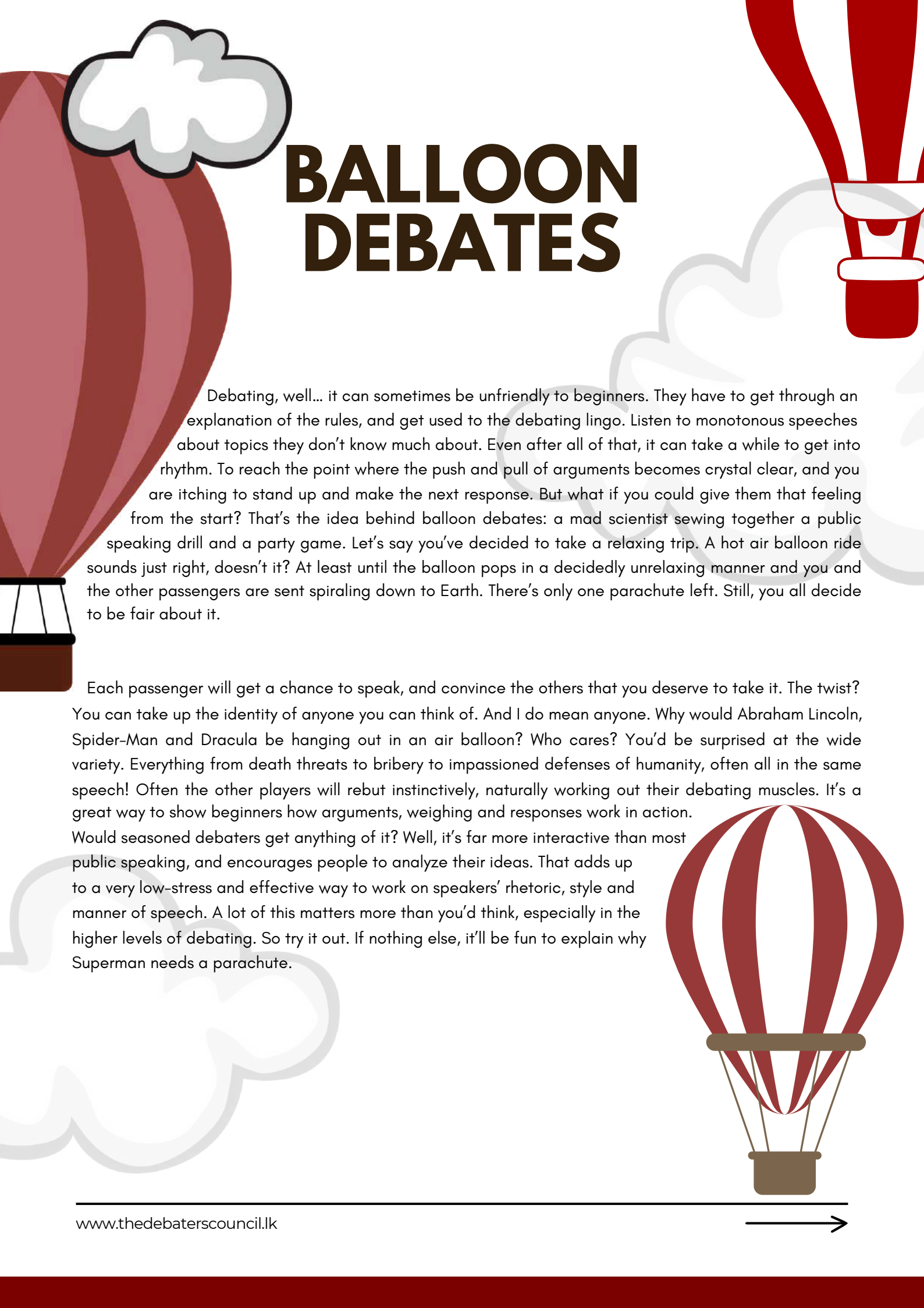
- **Savith Wijesundara** -

"Hang in there, keep learning and improving and focus on your own strengths rather than trying to force yourself into a mold."

- **Akein Bandara** -

"Work hard and reflect daily on what your weaknesses are and work on fixing them not just when you have a sudden spike in motivation, there needs to be constant commitment."

- **Nimansa Jayasundera** -



# BALLOON DEBATES

Debating, well... it can sometimes be unfriendly to beginners. They have to get through an explanation of the rules, and get used to the debating lingo. Listen to monotonous speeches about topics they don't know much about. Even after all of that, it can take a while to get into rhythm. To reach the point where the push and pull of arguments becomes crystal clear, and you are itching to stand up and make the next response. But what if you could give them that feeling from the start? That's the idea behind balloon debates: a mad scientist sewing together a public speaking drill and a party game. Let's say you've decided to take a relaxing trip. A hot air balloon ride sounds just right, doesn't it? At least until the balloon pops in a decidedly unrelaxing manner and you and the other passengers are sent spiraling down to Earth. There's only one parachute left. Still, you all decide to be fair about it.

Each passenger will get a chance to speak, and convince the others that you deserve to take it. The twist? You can take up the identity of anyone you can think of. And I do mean anyone. Why would Abraham Lincoln, Spider-Man and Dracula be hanging out in an air balloon? Who cares? You'd be surprised at the wide variety. Everything from death threats to bribery to impassioned defenses of humanity, often all in the same speech! Often the other players will rebut instinctively, naturally working out their debating muscles. It's a great way to show beginners how arguments, weighing and responses work in action. Would seasoned debaters get anything of it? Well, it's far more interactive than most public speaking, and encourages people to analyze their ideas. That adds up to a very low-stress and effective way to work on speakers' rhetoric, style and manner of speech. A lot of this matters more than you'd think, especially in the higher levels of debating. So try it out. If nothing else, it'll be fun to explain why Superman needs a parachute.

# TOURNAMENT RECAP

## JANUARY 2025

### AIS DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Asian International School Colombo Open, the first in the club's history, was held on the 3rd, 4th, and 5th of January 2025. The tournament featured five



preliminary rounds and an Octofinals break, along with a Novice break to the Semi-finals. In the Open category, Moir A emerged as Champions against DS A in the Grand Final, with Savith Wijesundara of

Moir A awarded Best Speaker. In the Novice category, BC Purple claimed the title against CIS Savith, while Anya Vithanage of CIS Savith was named Novice Best Speaker.

### S. W. R. D. BANDARANAYAKE MEMORIAL DEBATING TOURNAMENT 2025

St. Thomas' College organized the annual S. W. R. D. Bandaranaike Memorial Debating Tournament on the 24th, 25th, and 26th of January, with preliminary rounds held online and subsequent rounds at the college premises. After progressing through Partial Octo-finals, RC A emerged as Champions against AIS A in the Grand Final. Lehara Edirisinghe of AIS was awarded Best Speaker.

## FEBRUARY 2025

### APIIT INTER UNIVERSITY DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

APIIT Law School hosted the Inter University Debating Championship on the 22nd and 23<sup>rd</sup> of March



2025, organized by the Moot, Debate, and Mock Mediation Society (MDMMS) and endorsed by the Debaters' Council of Sri Lanka. The Grand Final featured the University of Moratuwa, the University of Peradeniya, the Royal Institute of Colombo, and a Cambridge-Durham team, with the University of Moratuwa emerging as Champions and Gavin Senaratne named Best Speaker.

## APRIL 2025

### D. N. WICKRAMASINGHE CHALLENGE TROPHY 2025



Ananda College Colombo and Visakha Vidyalaya hosted the D. N. Wickramasinghe Challenge Trophy 2025 from the 4th

to the 6th of April at Ananda College. The tournament featured a Quarters break, with eight teams advancing to the out rounds. In the Grand Final, RC B faced Metho A, with Royal College emerging as Champions.



## SOUTH ASIAN SCHOOLS DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Debaters' Council of Sri Lanka proudly hosted the South Asian Schools Debating Championship (SASDC) 2025 for the second consecutive year. Held on the 6th, 7th, and 8th of June, the tournament took place virtually across Zoom and Discord, bringing together talented debaters from across the region. The competition featured five preliminary rounds, after which the top 16 teams advanced to the Octo-finals, while four standout novice teams qualified for the Novice Semi-finals. After an intense series of debates, Team Korea- featuring Jian Hong, Bill Cho, Elliot Suh, Brooke Lai, and Connie Han, and Team Malaysia Merah- featuring Bernice Tan, Daphne Ngu, Wayne Ooi, Andrea Ong, and Megan Ong rose to the top as Grand Finalists. In a well-fought final, Malaysia Merah was crowned the Champions of SASDC 2025, with Team Korea finishing as runners-up. The Best Speaker of the tournament was Zhang XiaoYu of Team Singapore. In the novice division, Team BCW- comprising William Wang, Cynthia, and Bancheng Ni, emerged as champions, while Team The Unicorns, consisting of Dương Minh Khoa (Ben), Nguyễn Trần Khánh Chi (Vivian), and Lê Hồng Thảo (Flora), were named runners-up.

The Novice Best Speaker award was presented to Zhou Yi An of Team 'we're so flop'. The tournament was guided by an esteemed Core Adjudication Panel, including Jason Xiao (Chief Adjudicator, WSDC 2025), Chansol Park (DCA, WSDC 2025), Shalem Sumanthiran (WSDC 2020 Finalist), Hitishaa Goyal (2nd Best Speaker, WSDC 2023), and Pan Haotian (CAP, Oldham Cup 2025). SASDC 2025 concluded on a high note celebrating excellence, encouraging new voices, and further strengthening regional collaboration. It marked not just a tournament, but a growing chapter in Sri Lanka's presence on the global debating stage.



## JUNE 2025

### SRI LANKA SCHOOLS DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Sri Lanka Schools Debating Championship, organized by the Law Faculty of Colombo, was held on the 28th and 29th of June and the 5th of July 2025. D.S. Senanyake College and Royal College competed in an exciting final, in which Royal College emerged as Champions, with Adam Dilshan from Royal College being awarded Best Speaker.

## JULY 2025

### D.S. IMPROMPTUS' CHAMPIONSHIP 2025



The D.S. Impromptus' Championship 2025, organized by D.S. Senanayake College,

was held on the 11th, 12th and 13th of July, with Royal College and Trinity College emerging at finalists and Royal College winning the final on a 2-1 split. The Best Speaker was T. Tharaniharan from Royal College.

### APIIT ISDC 2025



The Asia Pacific Institute of Information Technology (APIIT) held their all island debate tournament on the 25th, 26th and 27th

July 2025. Girls' High School Kandy emerged as the Novice Champions, with Elizabeth Moir School becoming Runners Up in the standard category and Royal College emerging as the Champions. Raashid Cassim was awarded the title of Best Speaker.

## AUGUST 2025

### HULFTSDORP DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025



The Hulftsdorp Debating Championship was held on 2th and 3rd August 2025. RIC A, RIC B, and the University of Moratuwa reached the final, with Law College A clinching the Championship title.

The Best Speaker award went to Gavin Senaratne of the University of Moratuwa for his consistently outstanding performances. The Novice Final was won by Jekyll and Hyde—Sara Iman and Manura Paveen Thalís.

### RIC INTER SCHOOL DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Inter-School Debating Championship organized by the Royal Institute was held on the 8th, 9th and 10th of August 2025. Ladies College A became the Runners Up, whilst Bishop's College ultimately won the Championship. The Best Speaker position was tied between Sanchitha Wickrama from Trinity College and T. Tharaniharan from Royal College.

## REV. DR. STANLEY ABEYSEKARA MEMORIAL DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025



The Rev. Dr. Stanley Abeysekara Memorial Debating Championship hosted by St. Joseph's College took place on the 22nd, 23rd and 24th of August 2025, with St. Bridget's Convent emerging as the Runners Up and Ladies College winning the Championship. Mauli Kularatne from St. Bridget's Convent became the Best Speaker.

## VIJITHA WEERASINGHE MEMORIAL CHALLENGE TROPHY 2025

The Vijitha Weerasinghe Memorial Challenge Trophy hosted by Royal College was held on the 29th, 30th and 31st of August 2025. D.S. Senanyake College and Trinity College Kandy battled it out in the finals,



with D.S. Senanayake College securing the championship. Rudesh Ram from Colombo International School was awarded the title of Best Speaker.

## SEPTEMBER 2025

## HENLEY DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Henley debating championship 2025 organised by St. Bridget's Convent was an all island debate tournament held for the 4th consecutive time this year, on the 12th, 13th and 14th of September 2025, by the school English Debating Society with up to 36 teams, including over 160 participants. At this tournament, Colombo International School emerged champions, while Royal College emerged Runners - Up. The best speaker was Dihen Udumalagal a from S. Thomas's College.



## LILIAN NIXON'S ALL ISLAND DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Lillian Nixon's All Island Debating Championship was organized by Ladies College on the 26th, 27th and 28th of September. Colombo International School and Royal College emerged as finalists, with Colombo International School ultimately winning the championship. Rudesh Ram from Colombo International School was awarded the title of Best Speaker at the tournament.

## OCTOBER 2025

### NM PERERA MEMORIAL DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The NM Perera Memorial Debating Championship, organised by Ananda College, was held on the 10th, 11th and 12th of October 2025, with Ladies College and D.S Senanayake College emerging as finalists in a thrilling final that ended with Ladies College winning the Championship. The Best Speaker position was won by Nimuthu Pathiraja from Trinity College Kandy with an average speaker score of 76.90.

### FRANCES CHAPMAN ALL ISLAND DEBATING TOURNAMENT 2025



The Chapman's All Island Debating Tournament was organized by Bishop's College on October 31st and

November 1st and 2nd, with Asian International School and Royal College emerging as the finalists of the competition. Sanchitha Wickrama from Trinity College emerged as the Best Speaker of the tournament with an average speaker score of 77.00

## NOVEMBER 2025

### RI INTER UNIVERSITY DEBATE COMPETITION 2025



The IUDC hosted by RIC was held on the 22nd and 23rd of November 2025. Following several intense rounds,

the University of Moratuwa secured the Championship title. Gavin Senaratne from the University of Moratuwa was awarded Best Speaker.

## DECEMBER 2025

### THE COLONEL HENRY STEEL OLCOTT DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Colonel Henry Steele Olcott Debating Championship organised by Dharmaraja College was held on the 12th, 13th and 14th of December, with Visaka Vidyalaya emerging as Runners Up and Hillwood College Kandy becoming champions. Vidath Marasinghe from D.S. Senanayake College became Best Speaker, with an average Speaker Score of 76.5

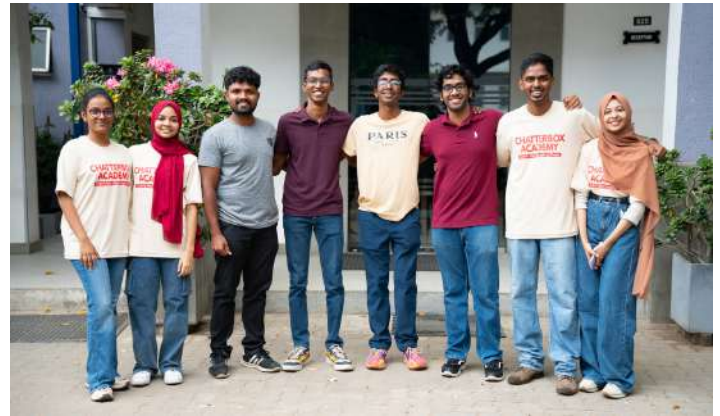
### LAKSHMAN KADIRIGAMAR ALL ISLAND DEBATING CHAMPIONSHIP 2025

The Lakshman Kadirigamar All Island Debating Championship was organized by Trinity College on the 19th, 20th and 21st of December, having been rescheduled due to suboptimal weather conditions. The two finalist teams were Royal College and Visaka Vidyalaya, with Visaka Vidyalaya emerging as champions on a 3-2 split. Rudesh Ram from Colombo International School became Best Speaker of the tournament with an average speaker score of 77.10

# WORKSHOPS

## KURUNEGALA WORKSHOP

The Debaters' Council of Sri Lanka successfully conducted a workshop in Kurunegala, bringing together over 110 enthusiastic participants from schools across the region. The sessions were led by Daniel Victor, Tharin Rajapakse, and Thisuru Praveen, alongside members of Chatterbox Academy. Designed to provide practical insight into competitive debating, the workshop featured interactive activities, strategy discussions, and guided practice rounds. Participants actively engaged with the speakers, gaining valuable exposure to structured argumentation, rebuttal techniques, and effective framing. The event marked a significant step in expanding debating opportunities beyond Colombo and strengthening the growing outstation debating community.



## KANDY WORKSHOP

The Debaters' Council of Sri Lanka also hosted a workshop in Kandy, drawing over 50 participants eager to refine their debating skills. The workshop was conducted by Akindu Athauda, Ammar Zafarullah, Anielka Nallathamby, Jayageeth Basnayake, Sanithma Jayasooriy and Shakeeb Mohideen. Through engaging sessions focused on strategy, clash, and impact analysis, participants were encouraged to think critically and approach debates with greater confidence. The interactive format fostered lively discussion and meaningful learning, creating a supportive space for both novice and experienced debaters. The workshop concluded on a high note, further solidifying the Council's commitment to regional debate development.



**APRIL 2025**

## DC AWURUDU CELEBRATIONS

DC Awurudu was organized by the Debaters' Council of Sri Lanka, in collaboration with the Circuit Development Volunteer Committee, and was held on the 26th of April at the Royal College Main Grounds, starting from 9:30 a.m.

The day began with the traditional ritual of milk boiling (kiri ithiraveema), symbolizing prosperity and blessings for the Sinhala and Tamil New Year. This was followed by a warm welcome speech delivered by Dineth Hettiarachchi, officially opening the day's festivities. Attendees then enjoyed a delightful spread of traditional New Year sweets while sharing fellowship and laughter.

The day's proceedings featured a variety of exciting and nostalgic games, including Dineththa Aha Thabeema, Vasana Mutti Bindeema, the Water Balloon Passing game, and Andayata Kiri Kaveema, all of which added energy and fun to the celebration. The event concluded with a friendly cricket match and the awarding of prizes to the winners.

The event concluded with warmth and laughter, reinforcing bonds within the Debaters' Council community.



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# A DEBATE DILEMMA

## THE RISK OF NOVELTY

Over the past five years or so of judging tournaments, I've come to realise that most debates fall into regular, predictable patterns. And I'm not talking about the meta of how debates evolve; the arguments themselves often feel cliché and familiar.

But is this the fault of the speaker, or is it an inherent flaw of debating itself?

Perhaps these arguments continue to be perpetuated across generations of debaters because they are just that effective.

I imagine a survival of the fittest of arguments where only the best ones survive to be used by next year's debaters. Arguments that feel stale or boring must have only survived so long because they kept on winning debates, right? And it is true that there are some things that need to be done in every debate whether you like it or not.

In a debate about criminal justice, it is a practical necessity to address the pillars of retribution, rehabilitation, incapacitation and deterrence. Move on to social justice, and you will never win without addressing the "most vulnerable stakeholder", whoever that may be.

But this raises the question: Are there a set of optimal arguments for every motion that you can find through some methodical or algorithmic approach? And if so, does that eliminate the need for creativity in debating?

I have always favoured making unorthodox and sometimes downright weird arguments simply because debating is more fun that way.

However, one of the drawbacks is that judges often have trouble buying novel arguments due to their, well, novelty. Everyone gets it once I explain myself after the debate, but by then it's too late.

Compare this to taking a stock argument from your matter file and adapting it to the specifics of the debate:

The judge has already seen ten variants of it, and has probably made the exact argument themselves. Thus, you need to do very little in terms of framing and analysis because your argument is intuitively acceptable.

Even as a coach, I find myself guiding kids to find arguments they should make instead of encouraging them to think outside the box about arguments they could make. It's a surefire method to make progress even if the results aren't exactly spectacular.

The problem with this approach is that your opponents are just as or even better prepared than you. This means they will probably have a set of equally believable responses to your argument in their own matter files.

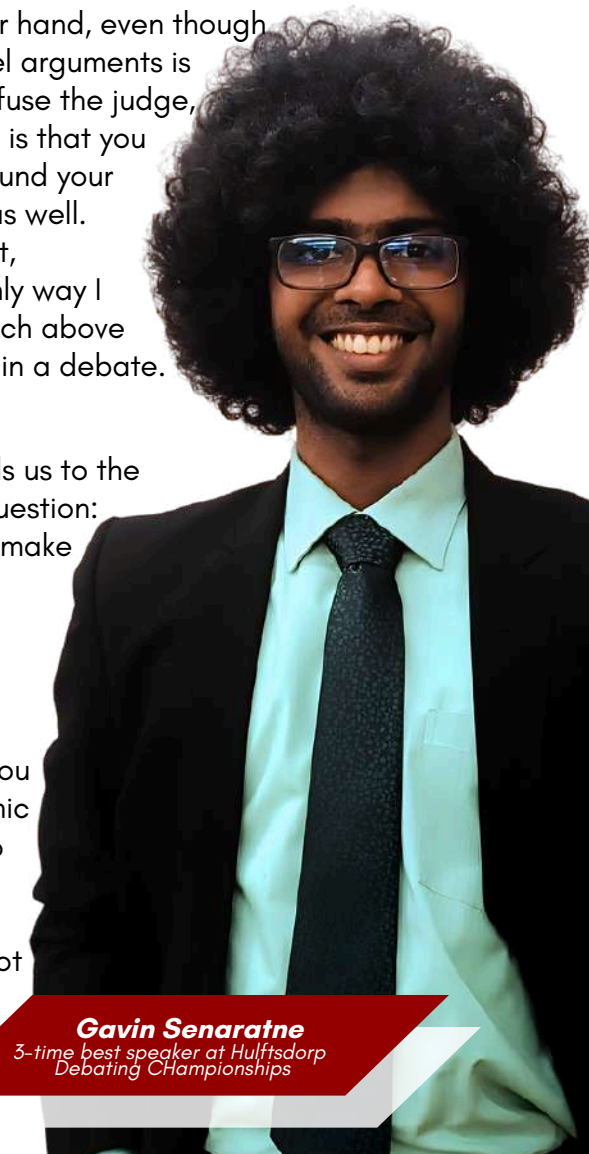
And that's the tradeoff of sacrificing novelty to make a risk-free case. Even though you might tick all the boxes of what you should do, you eliminate all chances of winning against a team that is more technically proficient than you.

Additionally, I've also found that it is very difficult to achieve high speaker scores without displaying some degree of creative thought in your speech.

On the other hand, even though making novel arguments is likely to confuse the judge, the tradeoff is that you might confound your opposition as well. To be honest, that's the only way I know to punch above your weight in a debate.

But this leads us to the inevitable question: how do you make creative arguments?

Think like a debater. If I could give you an algorithmic approach to do that, it would, by definition, not be creative.



**Gavin Senaratne**

3-time best speaker at Hultsdorp  
Debating Championships

## ? What was the turning point in your debating journey that made you improve significantly?

My teammate, Lehara, joining the team definitely changed my debating career. Before she joined, I had lost sight that debating was a team activity and took the entire burden on myself. When she joined, we began challenging each other and working together, elevating not just our team's performance but our individual skillsets too

**- Abdullah Yusoof**

The turning point in my debating journey was my friend Raashid's existence. It was being relegated from the A to B team in 2020 with him taking my place. It made me realize just how much I cared, which pushed me to work harder than ever before. Another key moment was being on a team with Suchith, our captain in 2021. He had a profound impact, shaping not only my growth as a debater but also my development as a teammate and a leader.

**- Adam Dilshan**

The main reason I was able to improve quite soon was due to my Coach, Sahas Gunsekera. He had a lot of belief in my potential and he gave me clear targets and constant motivation to achieve them. Additionally, getting selected for the National Pool of 2021 was also an important point in my debating career because it exposed me to a lot of new resources and methods of improving myself. I got the opportunity of working with the best debaters of the country and I got to learn many new techniques.

**-Sanithma Jayasooriya**

## ? What's one piece of debate advice you received early on that you still live by today?

Debating is 80 percent presentation. Sound convincing and you will convince most adjs. Be clear and concise with your language and you can get through a lot.

**- Abdullah Yusoof**

Advice I got early on from an older debater, Janul Aiya was that regardless of whether it's good luck or bad luck, it's always our fault. Like most debaters, I used to blame losses on motions, judges, or even positions, but this mindset stops growth and teaches nothing. What's important is realizing that even in unfavorable circumstances, the best debaters still maintain control over outcomes. It helped me understand that there are ways in which we have control over our luck, it just sometimes requires a bit of creativity.

**- Adam Dilshan**

"Control the controllables" was a piece of debating advice that I received from my National Pool Coach in 2021. I think this is incredibly important since it highlights the fact that our performance is the only thing that is within our control in a round and that there's no point worrying about the kind of motion or team that we'll end up getting. Whenever I've had to face strong teams, this is something that helped me a lot.

**-Sanithma Jayasooriya**

## ? What's a common piece of debate advice that you disagree with – and why?

The general idea that debaters should focus solely on content and deprioritize their style is something I disagree with. The essence of debating is logic, so content is very important. But so is the art of persuasion. Very often, the best debaters have the edge over other teams not because they can think of smart arguments, but because they can articulate them in a way that is passionate, stylistic, and phrased strategically. That makes them impossible to ignore..

**- Adam Dilshan**

## What was the worst round you've ever had – and what did it teach you?

Two debates come to mind. The first is LKS 2023 Round 2 against LC B—it was the first (and still only) time I've lost to a B Team. A well-deserved loss, too. It taught me the classic lesson that arrogance and overconfidence spell disaster. The other is the Nixon Finals in 2023 against Trinity College, which was probably my most humbling defeat. It reminded me of how far I still had to go to reach the top.

**- Adam Dilshan**

The worst round I've had was a round at Metho 2022 where my team slightly misunderstood part of the motion. We still managed to win the round because we made the right shift in our stance. To me it highlighted the importance of not giving up in the middle of a round until the last speech is over.

**-Sanithma Jayasooriya**

## Describe a specific issue or challenge you faced in debating and how you overcame it.

Debating can be very tiring. Sometimes when you don't get results despite the work you put in you feel like never trying again. All debaters go through this phase, but the important part is to never give up. I took a 6-7 month break from debating and came back with a renewed drive, realizing how much I missed it and that changed my approach to debating. It was about enjoying myself, not just the wins and the losses.

**-Abdullah Yusoof**

The "Quarters Curse" was a point in my career where my team at Hillwood College consistently lost quarters at tournaments. As a debater I had a high amount of determination. Every time my team lost, instead of trying to quit I focused on improving myself. Finally by the end of 2022 my team was able to win the most competitive tournament of the year which left me incredibly proud and happy. So, to all the teams suffering from such a "curse" right now, have faith and perseverance. I'm sure you guys have incredible things awaiting you.

**-Sanithma Jayasooriya**

## How do you personally deal with burnout or lack of motivation during the season?

I didn't do all the tournaments in any year's season due to other commitments, so my burnout wasn't as bad as it was for some others. I reminded myself why I enjoy debating and the thirst to keep improving help me power through.

**-Abdullah Yusoof**

For me, I dealt with it by skipping out on a tournament every now and then to keep my sanity. But what's more demotivating is how frequent losses are and how often debaters fall into a plateau where you either feel no improvement whatsoever or you feel as if you're getting worse. This is extremely normal and happens to everyone, and it's important to not take it too personally or feel as if you're incompetent or not smart enough. At the end of the day it really doesn't matter so much, so it's important to push yourself to enjoy debating, the community and practices regardless of the outcomes of rounds.

**- Adam Dilshan**

Personally I always had goals like getting into the national team some day which meant that every single speaker rank mattered since I had to enter the national pool. In 2021, I would always visit the debaters council website and look at the national team page which served as a good form of motivation for me. So I think it helps to have clear targets and break down what needs to be done to achieve them. Additionally, take it one step at a time. If your team is at a position where they're consistently breaking, your next goal should be winning octos, then quarters and so on. Breaking down broad targets into smaller ones will definitely help.

**-Sanithma Jayasooriya**

chickens in their  
developmental  
stages

an influencer  
puppy

wolves

aliens

Somapala

a worm

# WACKIEST STAKEHOLDER

YOU HAVE EVER DEBATED ON?

FT. THE SRI LANKAN DEBATING CIRCUIT

furries.

Himala

farm animals

Survivors on  
an Island  
with  
medieval  
weapons

a dyslexic child

racist cheesecake  
bakers

41 64 61 6d 20 44 68 69 6c  
73 68 61 6e

Sumanapala

money can't buy love  
because (my) loaded  
teammate could  
never get a girl

to demonstrate  
how unathletic  
some people are

prove that  
'natural  
selection' is  
failing

4.000 rupees in  
debt to the school  
canteen and is  
planning to pay it  
back in 'exposure'

...how to yap for 6  
minutes and still  
give a good speech

having an  
identity crisis

# TIME YOU USED YOUR TEAMMATE IN AN ARGUMENT?

FT. THE SRI LANKAN DEBATING CIRCUIT

why freedom  
of speech  
should be  
reconsidered

illustrate  
'extreme  
poverty'

hard work doesn't  
always pay off lol

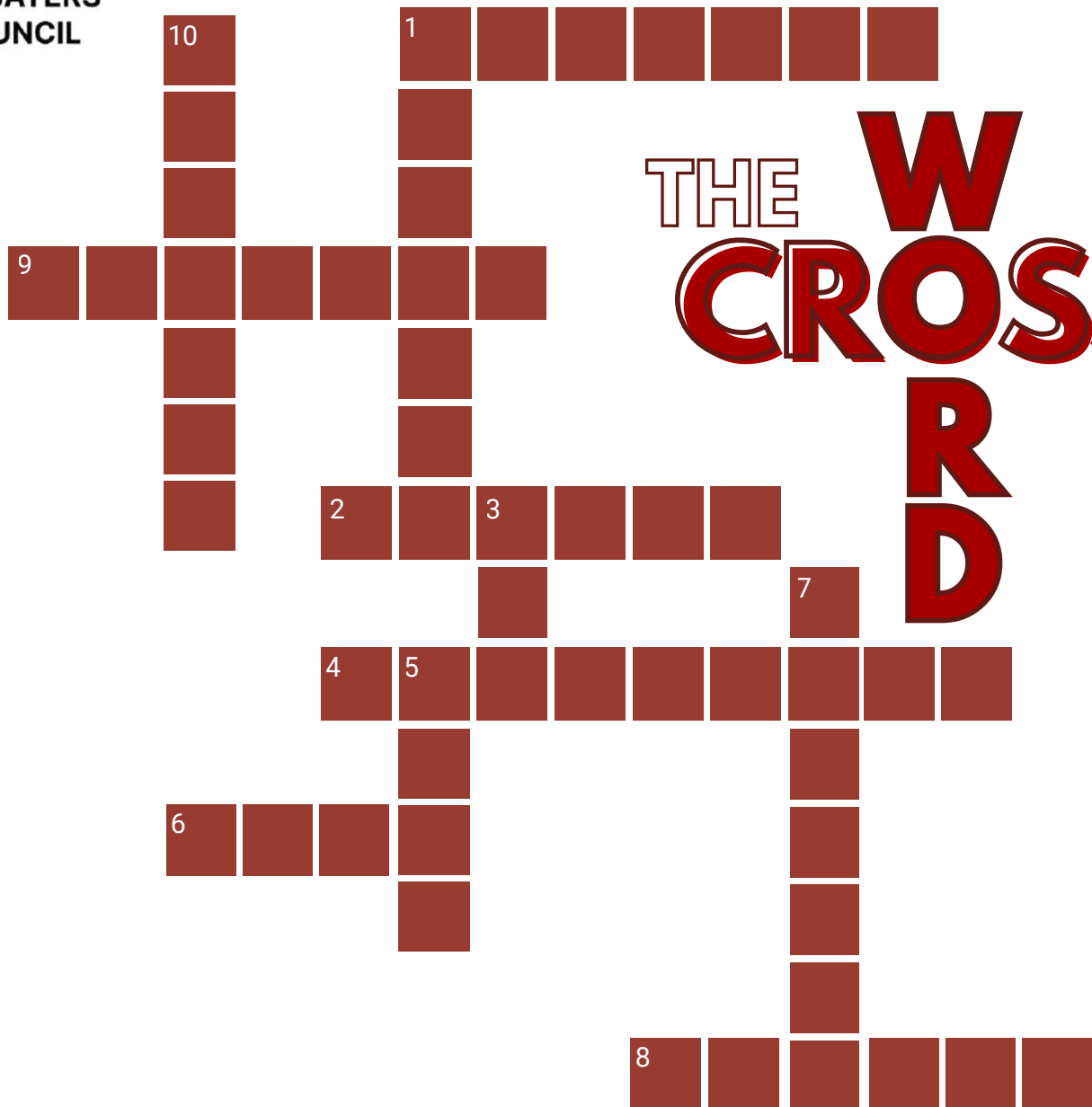
kids addicted  
to child  
lotteries

every single  
debate, I'm  
referring to  
6E 75 68 61 6E

how anyone could  
win this debate with  
their eyes closed -  
dedicated to my  
teammate who was  
sick and asleep

...that without queer books,  
I wouldn't know much  
about my teammate

case is more stable  
than their internet



## ACROSS

1. The most used line during COVID  
"Am I \_\_\_ and visibly clear?"
2. Go to phrase to say when they didn't listen to the POI but want to sound smart
4. A last minute team of chaos; either undefeated or 0/4 with high speaks
6. Where clash goes when both teams frame the same principle slightly differently and never engage
8. State of the Opp after the PM's framing leaves them no case left to run.
9. Major exclusive perk of the Kandy tournament

## DOWN

1. When the adj doesn't want to admit a debate was good, "It was an above \_\_\_ debate."
3. Taken aggressively before the last 60 seconds, but almost never answered properly.
7. The only format of debate where "burden of proof" is casually mentioned 12 times in a speech.
9. Word that's been redefined by politicians during every climate summit.
10. A Marvel superhero (AKA that one team member who stepped up to speak for their teammate who dropped out of the Zoom call).



# DC COMICS





[www.thedebaterscouncil.lk](http://www.thedebaterscouncil.lk)